MINUTES
VANCE COUNTY BOARD OF COMMISSIONERS
WORK SESSION
March 17, 2026

The Vance County Board of Commissioners held a work session on Tuesday, March 17, 2026, at 4:00 p.m. in the Commissioners' Conference Room, Vance County Administration Building, 122 Young Street, Henderson, NC. Those commissioners present were as follows: Chair Carolyn Faines, Vice Chair Charisse Fain, Commissioners: R. Dan Brummitt, Yolanda Feimster, Leo Kelly, Jr., and Valencia Perry.

Absent: Commissioner Thomas S. Hester, Jr.

Also present were County Manager C. Renee Perry, Assistant County Manager Jeremy Jones, Finance Director Stephanie Williams, County Attorney Jonathan S. Care, and Clerk to the Board Dywanda Pettaway.

Solid Waste Fee Waiver Policy. The Board received a report regarding the historical practice of waiving the solid waste household user fee without a formal policy or ordinance. It was noted that prior to FY 2016–2017, an ordinance allowed exemptions for unoccupied residences without electrical service; however, the ordinance was removed while the practice of granting waivers continued administratively.

In Summer 2025, the Tax Administrator identified this inconsistency. As a result, the County reinstated the fee for approximately 220 parcels pending Board direction. The current annual fee is approximately $146 per household, representing an estimated $29,000–$30,000 in potential revenue.

Staff expressed concerns regarding verification, administrative burden, and oversight if a waiver policy were reestablished. Documentation had previously been submitted by property owners (e.g., utility statements), though consistency and compliance were unclear. It was also noted that a prior refund had been issued retroactively, raising additional concerns.

A comparison of surrounding counties indicated that only one neighboring county currently allows such exemptions, while others do not.

Following discussion, the Board indicated consensus to maintain the current practice of collecting the fee and not pursue development of a waiver policy at this time.

AI Policy. The Board received a presentation on a proposed Artificial Intelligence (AI) policy developed in alignment with state and federal laws, guidelines, and best practices.

Staff stated the policy is intended to: (1) ensure AI is used ethically, responsibly, and legally; (2) address and mitigate potential bias; and (3) ensure AI does not replace human decision-making. The policy establishes operational "guardrails" governing acceptable AI use, including requirements for data control and protection of public records.

The policy also includes provisions for an annual AI transparency report, requiring departments to disclose AI systems in use, their purpose, and application. Departments are required to obtain IT approval prior to implementing AI tools.

Staff noted the urgency of adopting the policy due to upcoming software procurements containing AI components. Legal counsel has reviewed the policy and provided input.

Following discussion, the Board was advised that the policy will be presented for formal consideration and possible approval at the April 6 meeting. Board members were encouraged to review the document and provide feedback prior to that time.

Board of Equalization and Review. Ms. Perry discussed with the Board the potential establishment of a separate Board of Equalization and Review (ENR) in advance of the 2030 revaluation, following the transition from an eight-year to a six-year revaluation cycle.

Staff requested feedback on whether to retain the Board of Commissioners as the ENR or to create a separate appointed board. It was noted that practices vary statewide, with approximately a 50/50 split among counties.

It was noted that a separate ENR board could improve efficiency, reduce quorum challenges, and serve as a buffer between taxpayers and the Board of Commissioners. It was also noted that a separate board could provide specialized expertise and reduce the time burden on commissioners, particularly during revaluation years when appeal volumes are higher.

Legal counsel advised that establishing a separate ENR board would require adoption of a resolution, followed by a recruitment and appointment process, including consideration of qualifications, board composition, alternates, and per diem compensation. Early implementation and training (one to two years prior to the 2030 revaluation) were recommended.

The County's tax administrator shared with the board that other counties utilize boards consisting of individuals with relevant expertise, such as real estate and legal professionals, and that such structures can streamline the appeals process.

Following discussion, the Board reached a consensus to explore the creation of a separate ENR board. Ms. Perry will return with a proposed resolution and additional details for consideration at a future meeting.

Health Insurance Premium Supporting Information (employee survey results, other county data, etc.) Ms. Perry updated the board on the County's health insurance premiums. Staff reported a projected 5% increase in costs, raising the annual budget from approximately $4.0 million to $4.2 million.

An employee survey was conducted, with 60 employees supporting a proposed $50 premium and 95 opposing it. Supporting documentation was provided outlining plan costs and comparisons. It was noted that in the prior year, the County absorbed the majority of a 48% increase, covering approximately 38% while employees paid 10%, and historically has contributed toward dependent coverage.

It was further noted that the County's health plan also includes library and housing authority employees. Comparative data from the County's benefits broker indicated that most participating entities charge employee premiums, with only a small number offering fully covered plans.

Staff recommended consideration of implementing a $50 premium but advised that the Board could elect to absorb the additional cost. Due to open enrollment occurring in May, staff requested directions at the April 6th meeting to allow sufficient time for preparation.

Following discussion, Board members expressed varying perspectives, with some leaning towards absorbing the increase as an employee benefit. No action was taken, and the item will be brought back for decision at the April 6th meeting.

Headshots. Ms. Perry informed the Board that a photographer will be onsite April 1 at 4:00 p.m. to take professional headshots for the leadership team. Commissioners were offered the opportunity to participate at no additional cost, as the session is covered under a one-time fee.

To avoid a quorum, commissioners electing to participate will schedule individual appointment times through Dywanda. Participation is optional.

As there was no further business, at 4:41 p.m., the work session was adjourned.